

KEY TOPIC 1: THE BIRTH OF THE STATE OF ISRAEL, 1945–63

Paper 2: Conflict in the Middle East, 1945–1995



COURSE TEXTBOOK

Enquiry: Why has peace proved so elusive in the Middle East?

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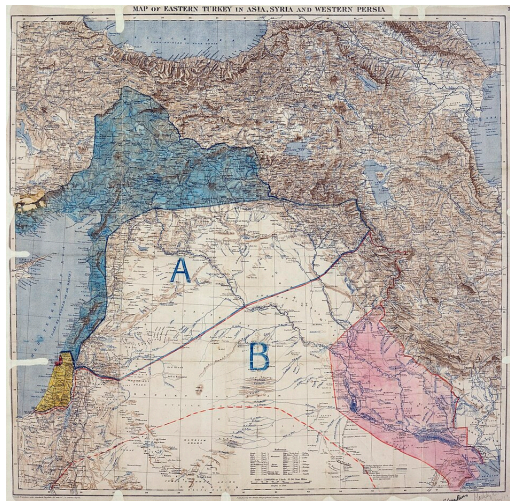
L1: KT 1.0: Foundational Geography & Geopolitics: Why the Middle East Ignited

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Analyse how the Sykes-Picot Agreement (1916) and League of Nations mandates drew artificial straight lines across former Ottoman territories.
- ☐ Evaluate the contradictory British wartime pledges: the McMahon-Hussein Correspondence (1915) versus the Balfour Declaration (1917).
- ☐ Identify the 4 strategic flashpoints of the Arab-Israeli conflict: Maritime Chokepoints, Elevated High Ground, Freshwater Basins, and Jerusalem.

The Middle East is the ultimate geopolitical crossroads of the earth—the physical land bridge connecting Europe, Asia, and Africa, the guardian of vital maritime chokepoints, and the birthplace of three world religions. To understand the bloody wars between Arabs and Israelis from 1945 to 1995, one must first understand its geography: how European diplomats drew straight ruler lines across deserts, why fresh water from the River Jordan is a matter of national survival, and why controlling the high ground of the Golan Heights or the narrow waters of the Straits of Tiran dictated the difference between victory and annihilation.

Source A : The Sykes-Picot Agreement Partition Map (8 May 1916)



The original 1916 map signed by British diplomat Sir Mark Sykes and French diplomat François Georges-Picot, carving the Ottoman Empire into British (Area B, red) and French (Area A, blue) spheres of imperial influence.

Q1. Why did British and French diplomats believe drawing straight lines across tribal, ethnic, and religious lands would remain stable, and why did this arbitrary imperial partition create over a century of chronic conflict?

Do Now Activity

Which three continents intersect at the Middle East, making it a critical strategic crossroads throughout world history?

What vital maritime waterway, completed in 1869 across Egypt, connects the Mediterranean Sea directly to the Red Sea?

What narrow body of water at the southern tip of the Sinai Peninsula controls maritime access to the Gulf of Aqaba and Israel's southern port of Eilat?

Which elevated volcanic plateau in south-western Syria directly overlooks the Sea of Galilee and northern Israeli civilian settlements?

Which freshwater river forms the natural eastern boundary of the West Bank, flowing south from the Sea of Galilee into the Dead Sea?

Which ancient city is considered a sacred holy sanctuary by Jews, Christians, and Muslims, and claimed as a capital by both Israelis and Palestinians?

Which vast triangular desert peninsula connecting Africa to Asia served as a major military buffer zone between Egypt and Israel?

What secret agreement in May 1916 saw British and French diplomats use a ruler to carve the collapsing Ottoman Empire into European spheres of influence?

What official British letter in November 1917 promised British support for the establishment of a "national home for the Jewish people" in Palestine?

Why is military control of "high ground" like the Golan Heights considered an indispensable defense asset in modern warfare?

Vocabulary Check

Write a short paragraph using at least *FOUR* of the vocabulary words below correctly.

Sykes-Picot Agreement | Mandate | Balfour Declaration | Zionism | Arab Nationalism | Chokepoint | Contested Territory



For over four centuries leading up to the First World War, the Middle East was ruled as part of the vast Turkish **Ottoman Empire**. The region was not divided into modern nation-states like Lebanon, Syria, Jordan, or Iraq; instead, it was administered as imperial provinces under the Ottoman Sultan in Constantinople.

When the Ottoman Empire joined World War One on the side of Germany in October 1914, Britain and France seized the opportunity to dismember the Turkish empire and expand their imperial dominance. In May 1916, British diplomat Sir Mark Sykes and French diplomat François Georges-Picot drew up the secret **Sykes-Picot Agreement**. Using a ruler across a map, they partitioned the region:

- **French Sphere:** Syria and Lebanon (coastal blue zone and Area A).

- **British Sphere:** Mesopotamia (modern Iraq) and Transjordan (Area B and red zone), securing oil routes to the Persian Gulf.
- **Brown Zone (Palestine):** Designated for international administration due to the religious sensitivity of Christian, Muslim, and Jewish holy sites in Jerusalem.

Following Allied victory in 1918, the newly formed **League of Nations** formalised this partition through the **Mandates System** at the San Remo Conference (1920). These straight-line borders completely ignored traditional tribal boundaries, religious sects (Sunni, Shia, Christian, Druze, Jewish), and natural geography. This artificial map sowed the seeds of chronic regional instability that persists to this day.

Q2. Explain why the Sykes-Picot Agreement and League of Nations mandates created artificial borders in the Middle East.

Q3. Source Detective: Study the 1916 Sykes-Picot Agreement map above. What does the straight pencil line drawn between the British and French zones reveal about European imperial priorities versus on-the-ground ethnic and religious realities?

Foreign Office,
November 2nd, 1917.

Dear Lord Rothschild,

I have much pleasure in conveying to you, on behalf of His Majesty's Government, the following declaration of sympathy with Jewish Zionist aspirations which has been submitted to, and approved by, the Cabinet

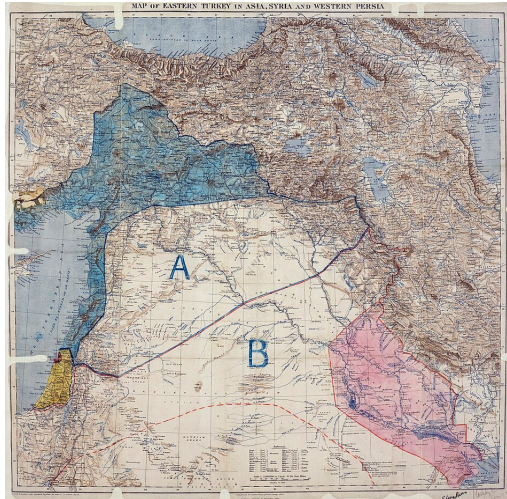
His Majesty's Government view with favour the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people, and will use their best endeavours to facilitate the achievement of this object. It being clearly understood that nothing shall be done which may prejudice the civil and religious rights of existing non-Jewish communities in Palestine, or the rights and political status enjoyed by Jews in any other country"

I should be grateful if you would bring this declaration to the knowledge of the Zionist Federation.

Y. in
Arthur Balfour



Source B : The Sykes-Picot Agreement Partition Map (May 1916)



The original partition map signed by Sir Mark Sykes and François Georges-Picot dividing the Ottoman Empire into British (red/B) and French (blue/A) spheres of control, placing Palestine under international administration.

Q4 Source Detective: Study the map. How did the secret partition into French (Zone A) and British (Zone B) spheres directly contradict the promises of an independent Arab kingdom made to Sharif Hussein in the McMahon-Hussein Correspondence?

During the desperate fighting of World War One, the British government made contradictory promises to both Arab and Jewish leaders in order to secure essential wartime support, creating a legacy of bitter betrayal.

1. The McMahon-Hussein Correspondence (1915–1916):

Sir Henry McMahon, British High Commissioner in Cairo, exchanged ten official letters with **Sharif Hussein of Mecca**, guardian of Islam's holiest sites. In exchange for the Arabs launching an armed rebellion (the Great Arab Revolt, assisted by T.E. Lawrence) against Ottoman forces, Britain pledged to recognize an independent, sovereign Arab kingdom across the Middle East. Arab leaders believed this pledge encompassed Palestine.

2. The Balfour Declaration (2 November 1917):

Just two years later, British Foreign Secretary Arthur Balfour sent an official letter to Lord Walter Rothschild, a prominent leader of the British Jewish community. The declaration stated: *'His Majesty's Government view with favour the establishment in Palestine of a national home for the Jewish people...'*. While it added that nothing should prejudice the civil and religious rights of existing non-Jewish communities, it made no mention of their political or national rights, despite Arabs making up over 90% of Palestine's population in 1917.

The Clash of Nationalisms:

- **Zionism:** Founded by Theodor Herzl in 1897 in response to violent European antisemitic pogroms. Zionists argued that Jewish people would never be safe from persecution without their own sovereign state in their ancestral biblical homeland (Eretz Israel / Palestine).
- **Arab Nationalism:** Arab leaders argued that having lived continuously in Palestine for centuries, the Arab majority possessed an indisputable natural right to national self-determination and independent statehood.

Britain had promised the exact same sliver of land to two different peoples with mutually irreconcilable aspirations.

Q5 Diplomatic Contradictions Matrix: Complete the comparative planner analyzing the three conflicting British wartime pledges during World War One:

Wartime Agreement	Date & Key Signatories	Recipient & British Commitment	Why It Contradicted Other Pledges

Q6. Explain the fundamental contradiction between the McMahon-Hussein Correspondence and the Balfour Declaration.



Understanding the physical geography of the Middle East is essential to understanding the military strategies, reasons for war, and peace negotiations of the Arab-Israeli conflict. The conflict centers on four critical spatial flashpoints:

- 1. **The Maritime Chokepoints (Suez Canal & Straits of Tiran):**
The **Suez Canal** links the Mediterranean Sea to the Red Sea, serving as the global trade artery between Europe and Asia. The **Straits of Tiran** are a narrow 3-mile bottleneck at the southern mouth of the Gulf of Aqaba, commanding Israel's southern maritime corridor from Eilat. Whenever Egypt blockaded the Straits (in 1956 and May 1967), it severed Israel's oil imports and trade lifeline with Asia, acting as a direct trigger for war.
- 2. **The Elevated High Ground (The Golan Heights):**
A volcanic plateau in south-western Syria rising 3,000 feet above the Sea of Galilee. Prior to 1967, Syrian artillery on the heights routinely bombarded Israeli farming settlements (kibbutzim) in the

Hula Valley below. Capturing the plateau in 1967 gave Israel indispensable defensive high ground and early radar detection over Damascus.

3. The Water Basin & Territorial Depth (The West Bank & River Jordan):

The hill country west of the River Jordan provides vital territorial depth. The **River Jordan** and the **Sea of Galilee** provide over 50% of the region's fresh water. Before 1967, Israel was only 9 miles wide at its narrowest waist near Tel Aviv; capturing the West Bank pushed the military frontier to the natural barrier of the Jordan Valley.

4. The Sacred Core (Jerusalem & The Old City):

One square kilometer of ancient stone containing the holiest sites of Judaism (The Western Wall / Temple Mount), Christianity (The Church of the Holy Sepulchre), and Islam (The Al-Aqsa Mosque and Dome of the Rock). Divided between Israel and Jordan along the 1949 Green Line, its capture by Israel in 1967 remains the emotional and political heart of the conflict.

Q7 Strategic Flashpoints & Chokepoints: Match each critical geographic flashpoint on the left with its decisive military significance on the right:

1. The Straits of Tiran (Gulf of Aqaba)	• •	Vital 120-mile maritime artery connecting the Mediterranean to the Red Sea, cutting 5,000 miles off trade routes between Europe and Asia.
2. The Golan Heights (South-western Syria)	• •	Elevated volcanic plateau giving Syrian artillery commanding sightlines to bombard civilian Israeli settlements across the Galilee plain.
3. The Suez Canal (Egypt)	• •	Israel's only southern maritime corridor for oil imports; its blockade by Egypt in 1956 and 1967 constituted an immediate act of war.
4. The River Jordan & West Bank Ridge	• •	Natural freshwater boundary and strategic mountain ridge providing essential defensive depth against ground invasion from the east.

Q8. Why were the Golan Heights and the Straits of Tiran of supreme strategic importance in the Arab-Israeli wars?

Map Task: The Geopolitical Landscape

Understanding the geography of the Middle East is the essential first step to understanding its history. The borders of the modern Middle East were largely drawn by Britain and France following the collapse of the Ottoman Empire at the end of the First

World War. These artificially imposed borders laid the groundwork for decades of instability.

At the heart of the conflict are several highly contested regions: the Gaza Strip, the West Bank, the Golan Heights, and the Sinai Peninsula. Additionally, control over strategic waterways—like the Suez Canal, the Straits of Tiran, and the River Jordan—has repeatedly triggered military escalation.

Pair & Share Activity

Q9. Discuss with your partner: Why is the geography of the Middle East so geopolitically important?

Source A

Reference Map



Q10. Using the blank map provided in your workbook (or the interactive map here), label the following:
- **Countries:** Israel, Egypt, Syria, Jordan, Lebanon, Iraq, Iran - **Capitals:** Jerusalem, Tel Aviv, Cairo, Damascus, Amman, Beirut - **Waterways:** Suez Canal, Straits of Tiran, Gulf of Aqaba, Red Sea, River Jordan, Mediterranean Sea - **Contested Zones (shade these):** Sinai Peninsula, Golan Heights, Gaza Strip, West Bank

Source C : The Sykes-Picot Agreement

Partition Map (May 1916)

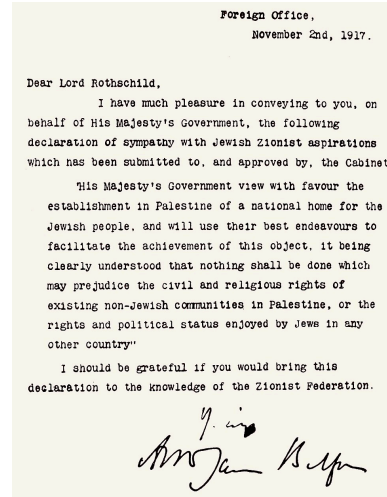


The official partition map signed by Britain and France in 1916 dividing the Middle East.

Q11 How does the straight line dividing Area A and Area B reveal the imperial priorities of Britain and France over local self-determination?

Source D : The Original Balfour Declaration

Letter (2 November 1917)



Official letter from British Foreign Secretary Arthur Balfour to Lord Rothschild expressing British support for a 'national home for the Jewish people' in Palestine.

Q12 What contradictory promises did Britain make to Arab and Jewish leaders between 1915 and 1917, and how did this letter ignite communal conflict?

L2: KT 1.1: The End of the British Mandate and the Creation of Israel, 1945–1949

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the conflicting interests and demands of Jews and Arabs within the British Mandate.
- ☐ Analyze the key events leading to the end of the British Mandate, partition and the creation of Israel, including the significance of the bombing of the King David Hotel and UN Resolution 181.
- ☐ Describe the key events of the Arab-Israeli war (1948–49).

In 1945, the world was reeling from the horrors of the Holocaust, creating immense international pressure for a Jewish homeland. Yet, for the Arab population of Palestine, this meant the terrifying prospect of losing their ancestral land. The British, exhausted and bankrupt from World War Two, were caught in the middle of an impossible situation.

Did you know?

- 1917: The Balfour Declaration originally promised British support for a national home for the Jewish people.
- 100,000: The number of Jewish Holocaust survivors US President Truman demanded Britain immediately allow into Palestine.
- 1947: The year Britain gave up and handed the Palestine problem to the newly created United Nations.

Source A : The Ruins of the King David Hotel, Jerusalem (July 1946)



Primary Photograph: The south-west wing of the King David Hotel collapsed after the Irgun bomb detonation on 22 July 1946, killing 91 British, Arab, and Jewish staff.

Q1. Source Detective: Why did the Irgun target the British administrative and military headquarters at the King David Hotel, and how did this attack convince the British government that maintaining the Mandate was untenable?

Do Now Activity

Which secret 1916 agreement between Britain and France partitioned the Middle East into European spheres of influence?

What official British declaration in November 1917 supported the establishment of a Jewish national home in Palestine?

What international body granted Britain the official Mandate to govern Palestine in 1920?

What was the political movement founded by Theodor Herzl aiming to create a sovereign Jewish homeland?

Why was the Suez Canal of supreme imperial importance to Great Britain?

What narrow maritime strait at the mouth of the Gulf of Aqaba links Israel's port of Eilat to the Red Sea?

Which elevated plateau overlooking Galilee was a major source of border clashes between Syria and Israel?

Which three world religions consider the Old City of Jerusalem sacred?

What freshwater river forms the natural boundary between the West Bank and Jordan?

What vast desert peninsula connects Africa to Asia and borders southern Palestine?

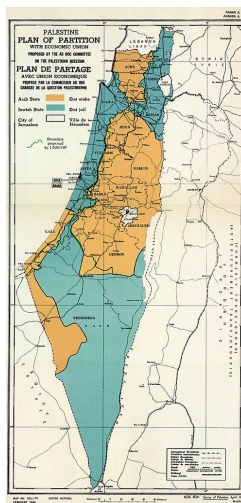
Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Mandate | Zionism | Irgun | Nakba

Your Sentence:

Source B : UN Partition Plan for Palestine (1947)



The proposed UN Partition Plan dividing Palestine into independent Arab and Jewish states, which was rejected by Arab leadership.

The British Dilemma & The League of Nations Mandate: Following the end of the Second World War in 1945, Great Britain found itself trapped in an increasingly untenable position within its League of Nations Mandate of Palestine. Under the terms of the Mandate, Britain was bound by a "dual obligation": on one hand, to establish a "national home" for the Jewish people (in line with the 1917 Balfour Declaration), and on the other, to safeguard the civil and religious rights of the existing Arab majority. As the full horrors of the Holocaust were revealed to the world, the international pressure for Jewish statehood became immense. In 1945, Zionist leaders gathered at a conference in London to demand the immediate creation of a Jewish state in Palestine, hoping that Britain would facilitate the resettlement of hundreds of thousands of Holocaust survivors currently languishing in European Displaced Persons (DP) camps.

Q2. What was the 'dual obligation' that Britain faced under the League of Nations Mandate of Palestine?

Arab Opposition & Demographic Realities: However, the Arab population—who formed the clear majority of Palestine's inhabitants—vehemently opposed this prospect. They resented not being granted independence at the end of the First World War and were furious that they had never been consulted regarding the mass resettlement of another population on their ancestral lands, which they had inhabited for over 1,500 years. Britain's newly elected Labour government, led by Prime Minister Clement Attlee and Foreign Secretary Ernest Bevin, immediately faced a crisis. Bevin set a strict immigration quota of just 1,500 Jewish immigrants per month. He did this for two primary reasons: 1. He calculated that allowing a massive influx of Jewish refugees would trigger an uncontrollable civil war between Arabs and Jews. 2. Britain was economically dependent on maintaining close, friendly relations with oil-rich Arab states across the Middle East. These states strongly opposed Zionist ambitions and would not tolerate unrestricted Jewish immigration.

Q3. Identify two reasons why Foreign Secretary Ernest Bevin set a strict immigration quota of 1,500 Jewish immigrants per month.

Zionist Militancy & Post-Holocaust Immigration: Angered by Bevin's strict immigration restrictions, Zionist organizations in Palestine abandoned the wartime truce they had maintained with the British. In October 1945, the moderate militia (the Haganah) joined forces with extreme paramilitary splinter groups—the Irgun (led by Menachem Begin) and the Lehi (also known as the Stern Gang). Together, they launched a coordinated, violent campaign known as the Jewish Insurgency to force a British withdrawal. While the moderate Haganah focused primarily on organizing illegal immigration (such as bringing Holocaust survivors on ships like the SS Exodus), the Irgun and Lehi targeted British military infrastructure. On 1 November 1945, the unified factions executed the Night of the Trains, blowing up the Palestine railway system in 153 places to paralyze British communications.

Q4 Chronological Causal Sequence: Order the following 5 key developments leading to the British decision to abandon Palestine from 1 (Earliest) to 5 (Latest):

- ☐ Ernest Bevin imposes a strict monthly quota of 1,500 Jewish immigrants to appease oil-rich Arab allies.
- ☐ The Haganah, Irgun, and Lehi form the United Resistance Movement to launch coordinated sabotage against British military infrastructure.
- ☐ The Irgun detonates explosives in the King David Hotel, destroying the British Mandate headquarters and killing 91 people.
- ☐ The Royal Navy boards the SS Exodus and forcibly returns 4,500 Holocaust survivors to displaced persons camps in Europe.
- ☐ Faced with public outrage over the 'Sergeants Affair' and a £100m annual policing cost, Britain hands Palestine to the United Nations.

Q5. What was the 'Jewish Insurgency' and which three Zionist groups united to launch it?

The Escalating Insurgency & Martial Law: Over the next two years, the insurgency intensified. Paramilitary groups bombed bridges, sabotaged oil pipelines, raided military airfields, destroyed radio stations, and assassinated British personnel. In 1946 alone, 73 British troops were killed. To destroy British military morale, Begin's Irgun engaged in psychological warfare; when two Irgun members were sentenced to caning in December 1946, Begin ordered the kidnapping and public whipping of four British soldiers in retaliation. The single deadliest act of the insurgency occurred on 22 July 1946, when the Irgun bombed the King David Hotel in Jerusalem. The hotel's southern wing housed the central administrative headquarters of the British Mandate and the military command of the British Army in Palestine. Under the cover of midday deliveries, Irgun fighters disguised as Arab workers rolled milk churns packed with TNT into the basement kitchen of the southern wing.

Q6. Describe the deadliest act of the insurgency on 22 July 1946 and explain its intended target.

Source C : The Sergeants Affair (July 1947)



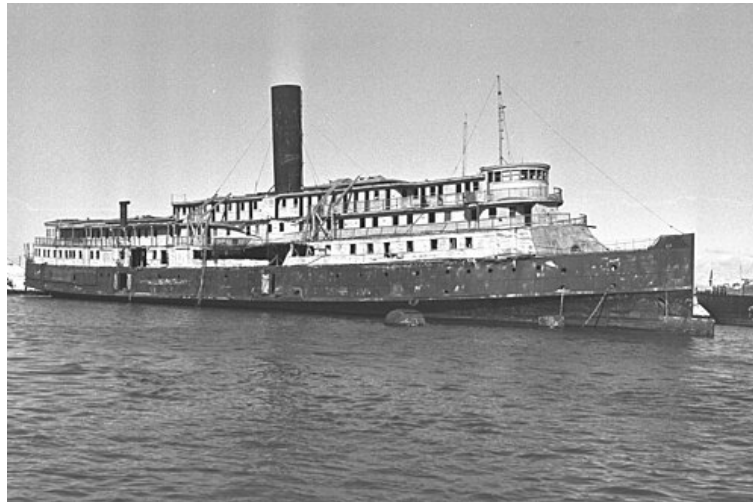
Primary Photograph: British Army Intelligence Corps sergeants Clifford Martin and Mervyn Paice, hanged by the Irgun in a eucalyptus grove near Netanya on 31 July 1947. The bodies were booby-trapped with a mine in retaliation for British executions of Irgun militants.

Q7 Source Detective: Study Source B. Why did the execution and public display of the two British sergeants create such overwhelming political pressure on Clement Attlee's government to surrender the Mandate?

The King David Hotel Bombing (July 1946) & The Sergeants Affair (July 1947): At 12:37 PM on 22 July 1946, a colossal explosion ripped through the King David Hotel in Jerusalem, causing the entire six-story southern wing to collapse into rubble. The attack killed 91 people—including 41 Arabs, 28 British officials, 17 Jews, and several other nationalities. The vast majority of the victims were innocent civilians. The sheer scale of the carnage shocked the British public, drove a wedge between the moderate Haganah and the militant Irgun, and required over 100,000 British troops to enforce martial law. However, the boiling point of British public tolerance was reached in July 1947 during the 'Sergeants Affair'. In retaliation for the British execution of three Irgun prisoners at Acre Prison, Menachem Begin's Irgun abducted two young British Army Intelligence Corps non-commissioned officers, Sergeants Clifford Martin (21) and Mervyn Paice (20). Despite desperate family appeals and extensive military searches, the Irgun hanged both men and suspended their booby-trapped bodies from eucalyptus trees near Netanya. When British forces discovered the corpses, an anti-personnel mine detonated, severely wounding a British officer. The graphic photograph of the hanging soldiers was splashed across British front pages, triggering anti-Jewish riots in Liverpool, London, and Manchester, and shattering any remaining political will in London to maintain the Mandate.

Q8. How did the British public react to the 'Sergeants Affair', and what was the political result?

Source D : The SS Exodus Arriving in Haifa (July 1947)



The President Warfield (renamed SS Exodus 1947) carrying 4,500 Holocaust survivors intercepted by the Royal Navy.

Q9 Source Detective: How did Britain's decision to forcibly deport Holocaust survivors back to displaced persons camps in Europe destroy British diplomatic standing in the United States?

The SS Exodus & British Abdication: The public reaction in Britain was explosive. Angry anti-Semitic riots erupted in major British cities. Faced with a war-weary public demanding that the government 'bring the boys home,' Prime Minister Attlee and Foreign Secretary Bevin admitted that Palestine had become ungovernable. Unable to find a compromise that satisfied both Jewish and Arab demands, Britain formally referred the entire problem to the newly created United Nations (UN) in February 1947. The United Nations Special Committee on Palestine (UNSCOP) concluded that the only viable solution was the partition of the territory into separate Jewish and Arab states, with Jerusalem administered as an international zone (corpus separatum) under UN control. On 29 November 1947, the UN General Assembly voted on Resolution 181. The US and Soviet Union both supported partition, hoping to expand their own influence.

Q10 UN Resolution 181 Partition Matrix: Complete the comparative table below analyzing the territorial allocations and reactions to the 1947 UN Partition Plan:

Dimension	Proposed Jewish State	Proposed Arab State	City of Jerusalem (Corpus Separatum)

Q11. How did the United Nations Partition Plan (Resolution 181) divide the land of Palestine, and what was the reaction of the two communities?

UN Resolution 181 & The Partition Plan (November 1947): The final vote was 33 in favor, 13 against, and 10 abstentions. Under Resolution 181, the Jewish population (which owned less than 10% of the land and made up only one-third of the population) was allocated 55% of Palestine, including the fertile coastal plains. The Arab majority was allocated just 45% of the land, much of it mountainous and fragmented. While the Zionist leadership accepted the plan with joy, Arab leaders and the Arab League rejected it, declaring that they would fight to prevent the partition of their homeland. The passage of Resolution 181 acted as the catalyst for immediate violence. In December 1947, Britain announced that it would formally terminate its Mandate and withdraw all forces on 15 May 1948. For the remaining five months, British troops stood aside and refused to intervene, leaving Palestine to slide into a bloody, chaotic civil war between Jewish and Arab communities.

Civil Conflict & Plan Dalet (Spring 1948): In March 1948, the leadership of the Haganah implemented Plan Dalet (Plan D). Many historians argue that Plan D was a defensive military strategy designed to secure the borders of the future Jewish state by taking control of all Arab towns. Other historians argue that Plan D was an offensive operation that intentionally cleared Arab populations from strategic areas, effectively paving the way for the systematic ethnic cleansing of Palestine. The most critical flashpoint of the civil war occurred on 9 April 1948, when approximately 100 fighters from the extremist Irgun and Lehi launched an assault on Deir Yassin, a quiet Arab village. The attack resulted in the brutal massacre of over 100 Arab villagers. Hoping to rally the Arab world to intervene, Arab radio stations broadcast sensationalized, graphic accounts of the atrocities at Deir Yassin. However, this triggered widespread, uncontrollable panic among the Arab population. Believing that they would face the same brutal fate if they stayed, over 250,000 Palestinian Arabs abandoned their homes and fled in terror.

Q12. What was the impact of the Deir Yassin massacre on the Palestinian Arab population in April 1948?

Source E : David Ben-Gurion Declaring the State of Israel (14 May 1948)



David Ben-Gurion reads the Declaration of Independence at the Tel Aviv Museum beneath Theodor Herzl's portrait.

Q13 Source Detective: Why did Ben-Gurion choose to declare independence beneath the portrait of Theodor Herzl on the exact afternoon British forces withdrew?

The Declaration of the State of Israel (14 May 1948): On 14 May 1948, the last British troops departed Palestine. That afternoon, David Ben-Gurion stood in Tel Aviv and officially declared the birth of the sovereign State of Israel. The very next day, on 15 May 1948, five sovereign Arab nations—Egypt, Syria, Jordan, Lebanon, and Iraq—committed their armies to a coordinated invasion of the newly declared state, launching the first official Arab-Israeli War. At the outset, the survival of Israel hung in the balance. Jewish forces were heavily outnumbered, short of heavy weaponry, and faced a multi-front assault. By June, both sides were exhausted, and on 11 June 1948, the United Nations intervened, brokering a crucial one-month truce managed by UN mediator Count Folke Bernadotte.

The 1948–49 Arab-Israeli War & The First Truce: Israel used this one-month breathing space with exceptional efficiency. Prime Minister David Ben-Gurion dissolved the independent paramilitary groups and unified them into a single, professional national army: the Israeli Defence Forces (IDF). In direct violation of the UN weapons embargo, Israel used massive financial donations to purchase modern military hardware from Soviet-controlled Czechoslovakia, completely neutralizing the Arabs' initial material superiority. When the truce expired on 9 July 1948, the newly equipped IDF immediately went on the offensive, catching the Arab forces completely by surprise. In October 1948, Israel breached the second truce to launch its final offensives. Exhausted and politically divided, the Arab states signed separate Armistice Agreements with Israel between February and July 1949.

Q14. Describe the tactical advantage Israel gained during the first UN truce in June 1948.

The 1949 Armistice & The Green Line: The armistice borders of 1949, known as the 'Green Line,' fundamentally redrew the political map. Instead of the 55% allocated under the UN Partition Plan, Israel's victory secured control of 79% of mandate Palestine. An independent Palestinian Arab state ceased to exist. Over 700,000 Palestinians were permanently displaced from their homes, becoming refugees in neighboring states. The historical narrative of this displacement remains deeply contested. Traditional Israeli historiography argued that Palestinians left voluntarily under the orders of Arab leaders who promised they could return after the Jews were defeated. Conversely, Palestinian historians, and later Israeli 'New Historians' utilizing declassified IDF archives, demonstrated that the vast majority were

driven out by a combination of deliberate military expulsion (such as Plan Dalet), psychological warfare, and the terror induced by massacres like Deir Yassin. For the Palestinian people, the loss of their homeland and the subsequent refugee crisis is known as the Nakba ('The Catastrophe').

Q15. Explain the conflicting historical views regarding the displacement of over 700,000 Palestinians during the 1948 war.

Pair & Share Activity

Q16. If you were the British government in 1945, exhausted by WWII and facing attacks from Jewish paramilitaries, what would you have done with the Mandate?

Historian's Corner: The Debate over Plan Dalet

Historians sharply disagree on the nature of Plan D. Traditional Israeli historians argue it was a purely defensive necessity to secure besieged Jewish settlements before the Arab armies invaded. However, 'New Historians' like Ilan Pappé argue the text of Plan D proves it was a deliberate blueprint for the systematic ethnic cleansing of Palestinian Arabs from the future Jewish state.

Q17. How does Pappé's interpretation of Plan Dalet fundamentally change our understanding of the Palestinian refugee crisis?

Source F : The Ruins of the King David Hotel, Jerusalem (July 1946)

The south-west wing of the King David Hotel collapsed after the Irgun bomb detonation, killing 91 British, Arab, and Jewish personnel.

Q18 What does Source A reveal about the vulnerability of British authority in Palestine by July 1946?

Source G : The Sergeants Affair, Netanya (July 1947)

British Army Intelligence Corps sergeants Clifford Martin and Mervyn Paice hanged by the Irgun in a eucalyptus grove near Netanya.

Q19 Study Source B. Why did this photograph decisively convince the British public and government that Britain must leave Palestine?

Source H : The SS Exodus Intercepted off Palestine (July 1947)

The SS Exodus carrying 4,500 Holocaust survivors intercepted by the Royal Navy and returned to displaced persons camps in Germany.

Q20 How did Source C damage Great Britain's international standing during the UN debate on Palestine?

L3: KT 1.2: The Aftermath of the 1948–49 War & The Palestinian Refugee Crisis

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the territorial changes and their impact, including the refugee status of Palestinian Arabs.
- ☐ Understand the creation of the Israeli Defence Forces (IDF) and the Law of Return (1950), and the importance of US aid to Israel.
- ☐ Analyze Israel's relations with Egypt in the aftermath of the war.

The moment Israel declared independence on 14 May 1948, five Arab armies invaded. What followed was a desperate fight for survival for the Israelis, and a catastrophic loss of land for the Palestinians—an event they remember as the 'Nakba' (Catastrophe). The map of the Middle East was forever redrawn.

Did you know?

- 700,000: The approximate number of Palestinian Arabs who fled or were expelled from their homes during the war.
- 78%: The amount of Mandatory Palestine that Israel controlled by the end of the war, far more than the UN Partition Plan.
- 1949: Armistice agreements were signed, but no Arab state officially recognised Israel's right to exist.

Source A : Palestinian Refugees Fleeing Galilee During the 1948 Nakba



Palestinian Arab families evacuating their villages in Galilee carrying their remaining household belongings on donkeys and foot in late 1948.

Q1. How does this photograph demonstrate the human scale and trauma of the Palestinian refugee crisis (the Nakba) that followed the 1948–49 War?

Do Now Activity

Which international organisation was given responsibility for deciding the future of Palestine in 1947?

What was the number of the UN Partition Plan passed on 29 November 1947 dividing Palestine?

What percentage of Mandatory Palestine was allocated to the proposed Jewish state under Resolution 181?

What status was proposed for the city of Jerusalem under the 1947 UN Partition Plan?

How did Arab leaders and the Arab Higher Committee respond to UN Resolution 181?

On what date did David Ben-Gurion officially proclaim the declaration of the State of Israel?

What occurred on the day immediately following Israel's declaration of independence?

What was the Jewish paramilitary force that formed the foundation of the newly created Israeli Defence Forces (IDF)?

What Jewish militant group bombed the British headquarters at the King David Hotel in July 1946?

Which European superpower provided crucial initial diplomatic recognition and permitted Czech arms shipments to Israel in 1948?

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **Green Line**

Source B : Israeli Troops in Heavy Fighting During the 1948 War



Israeli soldiers fighting along the central front during the 1948 Arab-Israeli War.

Q2 Source Detective: How did the newly formed IDF successfully counter five invading Arab armies despite being heavily outnumbered in early 1948?

The 1949 Armistice Agreements & The Green Line: The signing of separate Armistice Agreements between Israel and its Arab neighbors (Egypt in February, Lebanon in March, Transjordan in April, and Syria in July 1949) formally ended the military hostilities of the first Arab-Israeli War but left a highly volatile political landscape. The armistice lines, drawn in green ink on the negotiators' maps and thereafter referred to as the 'Green Line,' fundamentally redrew the geography of the Middle East. Rather than the 55% of mandate Palestine allocated under the 1947 UN Partition Plan, Israel's military victory secured control over 75% to 79% of the territory, including the fertile coastal plains, the Galilee, the Negev Desert, and a secure corridor to West Jerusalem.

The Disintegration of the Proposed Arab State: The remaining portions of mandate Palestine were occupied by neighboring Arab states, entirely preventing the creation of an independent Palestinian Arab state. The West Bank and East Jerusalem were occupied and subsequently annexed by King Abdullah of Transjordan, a unilateral move designed to expand his Hashemite kingdom that was widely condemned as illegal by the rest of the Arab world. Meanwhile, the Gaza Strip—a narrow coastal territory crowded with

displaced refugees—was placed under the military and administrative control of Egypt. Jerusalem itself was left deeply divided, with barbed wire, concrete walls, and military checkpoints separating Israeli-controlled West Jerusalem from Jordanian-controlled East Jerusalem.

Q3 Territorial Transformation Matrix: Complete the table comparing the 1947 UN Partition Plan boundaries with the actual 1949 Armistice (Green Line) outcomes:

Territory / Region	Allocated Under UN 181 (1947)	Actual Outcome Under 1949 Armistice	Controlling Authority after 1949

Q4. What happened to the remaining portions of mandate Palestine (the West Bank and Gaza Strip) following the 1948-49 war?

Source C : Palestinian Refugees Leaving Their Villages (1948 Nakba)



Authentic UN Archival Photograph: Palestinian families carrying bundles of clothing and food as they flee their homes in 1948.

Q5 Source Detective: How did the displacement of over 700,000 Palestinians create an unresolved humanitarian and territorial crisis that shaped every subsequent conflict?

The Palestinian Refugee Crisis (The Nakba): For Palestinian Arabs, the immediate aftermath of the war was a tragedy of historic proportions, remembered as the Nakba ('The Catastrophe'). Approximately 700,000 Palestinian Arabs—representing over half of the Arab population of mandate Palestine—were permanently displaced from their ancestral homes. These refugees fled or were forcibly expelled by advancing Jewish forces during the fighting, seeking safety in the neighboring territories of Jordan, Syria, Lebanon, the West Bank, and the Gaza Strip. To cope with this vast humanitarian emergency, the United Nations General Assembly established the United Nations Relief and Works Agency (UNRWA) in December 1949. UNRWA constructed and managed dozens of temporary refugee camps, providing basic food rations, emergency tents, rudimentary healthcare, and elementary schooling.

Q6. How did the United Nations attempt to cope with the vast humanitarian emergency created by the displacement of 700,000 Palestinian Arabs?

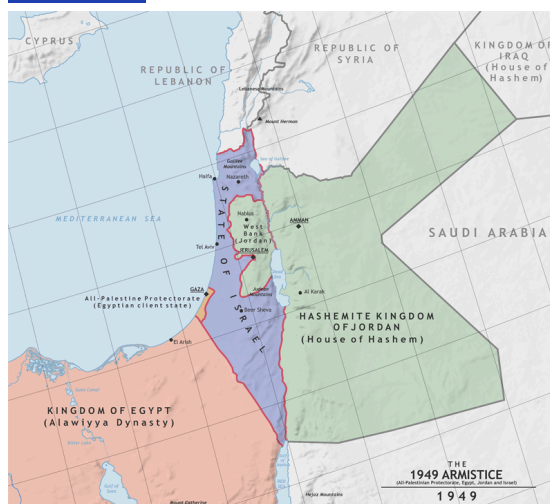
The Deadlock Over UN Resolution 194 & The Right of Return: Despite the end of the war, a permanent resolution to the crisis was blocked by deep political divisions. Israel strictly denied the Palestinians their 'right of return' to their former homes. The Israeli government argued that allowing hundreds of thousands of hostile Arab refugees to return would destroy the Jewish majority, compromise national security, and undermine the sovereign Jewish character of the state. Conversely, the Arab host states (with the exception of Jordan) refused to grant the refugees citizenship or integrate them into their national societies. They insisted that the camps must remain intact to prevent the international community from forgetting the Palestinian issue and to keep permanent diplomatic and moral pressure on Israel to honor the right of return. As a result, generations of Palestinians were left stranded in squalid, overcrowded camps, suffering from poor sanitation, deep economic poverty, and a permanent lack of civil rights.

Q7 The Refugee Deadlock Matrix: Complete the table analyzing the opposing policies and rationales regarding the displaced Palestinian refugees:

Key Actor	Official Policy on Palestinian Refugees	Strategic & Political Rationale

Q8. Why did both Israel and the Arab host states refuse to permanently integrate the Palestinian refugees into their societies?

Source D : The 1949 Armistice Green Line



Map showing the 1949 armistice lines: Israel gained 78% of the territory, while Jordan annexed the West Bank and Egypt administered Gaza.

Q9 Source Detective: Compare the 1949 Green Line with the 1947 UN Partition Plan: which areas did Israel capture beyond its original UN allocation?

Israeli Security & Mass Jewish Immigration (Aliyah): Faced with permanent hostility from its neighbors, the fledgling State of Israel focused intensely on consolidating its security and building up its population. On 26 May 1948, Prime Minister David Ben-Gurion issued a decree officially establishing the Israeli Defence Forces (IDF). This measure was highly significant because it systematically dismantled and banned the independent paramilitary groups (the Haganah, the Irgun, and the Lehi) that had operated during the British Mandate and the civil war, unifying them under a single, highly professional state command. The creation of the IDF gave Israel a powerful national army capable of defending its highly vulnerable borders against future Arab invasions. To bolster national security, Israel implemented a system of compulsory military conscription for its citizens, transforming the state into a highly mobilized 'nation in arms'.

Q10. Why was the establishment of the Israeli Defence Forces (IDF) in May 1948 highly significant for Israel's internal politics and national security?

The Law of Return (1950) & Demographic Transformation: To solve its demographic vulnerability, the Israeli Knesset passed the Law of Return in July 1950. This landmark legislation declared that any Jew anywhere in the world had the legal right to immigrate to Israel and secure immediate, automatic citizenship. This policy triggered an immense demographic boom, doubling Israel's population within just a few years. The influx included hundreds of thousands of Holocaust survivors from Europe and Jewish refugees expelled from Arab nations across the Middle East who had lost their properties and livelihoods. Although the massive wave of immigration strained Israel's fragile housing and food supplies, it was highly important because it provided a massive, determined workforce to develop the economy and supplied the IDF with a constant stream of military manpower to protect the state.

Q11. Explain the demographic impact of the 1950 Law of Return on the new State of Israel.

The Austerity Regime (Tzena) & Economic Survival: In its early years, Israel faced severe economic crises that threatened to collapse the state from within. The young country had to fund a massive military defense budget, build housing for hundreds of thousands of destitute immigrants arriving under the Law of Return, and survive a total economic boycott implemented by the Arab League, which banned all trade with Israel and penalised foreign companies that did business with the Jewish state. In this precarious position, direct financial and political aid from the United States was absolutely critical to Israel's survival. President Harry S. Truman, driven by strong domestic sympathy for Holocaust survivors and intense political lobbying, quickly recognized Israel and authorized massive emergency loans and grants. This massive US aid to Israel became a vital economic lifeline that allowed the young nation to absorb immigrants and build its defense forces.

Q12. Why did President Harry S. Truman authorise massive emergency loans and grants to Israel in its early years?

German Reparations (1952) & National Development: These funds allowed the Israeli government to buy food, build infrastructure, establish agricultural settlements, and import vital materials to industrialize the country. This early financial pipeline established a powerful strategic relationship between the United States and Israel, which deepened as Cold War rivalries intensified in the Middle East. The 1949 armistice did not lead to a lasting peace, and relations between Israel and its most powerful neighbor, Egypt, remained intensely hostile. Egypt refused to recognize Israel's right to exist and took active measures to strangle the new state economically and militarily.

Source E : Palestinian Refugee Camps (UNRWA, 1949)



Source

Palestinian refugees displaced by the 1948 war, who would later be supported by UNRWA.

Fedayeen Border Infiltration & Retaliation Raids: Egypt closed the internationally vital Suez Canal to all Israeli ships and systematically searched neutral vessels, confiscating any cargo purchased at Israeli ports or bound for Israel's armed forces. Furthermore, from 1951, Egyptian forces established a permanent military blockade at the Straits of Tiran (Sharm el-Sheikh), stopping all foreign cargo vessels heading toward Israel's southern port of Eilat, completely choking Israeli trade with Asia and East Africa.

Egypt also utilized the Gaza Strip—which it controlled—as a launchpad for Fedayeen (Palestinian guerrilla) raids. These displaced refugees launched cross-border attacks into Israel to sabotage infrastructure, steal livestock, and kill Jewish civilians.

Q13. Describe two ways that Egypt attempted to strangle Israel economically and militarily in the early 1950s.

Unit 101 & Ariel Sharon: The Deterrence Doctrine: To counter this threat, David Ben-Gurion implemented a severe reprisal policy, ordering the IDF to respond to every border raid with disproportionate military force against Egyptian military posts to deter future attacks. This created a violent, escalating border war that kept the region on the brink of conflict. This border tension escalated dramatically in July 1952, when the corrupt and pro-Western King Farouk of Egypt was overthrown in a military coup by the Free Officers Movement. This coup eventually brought the charismatic and fiercely anti-Western Colonel Gamal Abdel Nasser to power in Egypt. Nasser's championing of Pan-Arabism and his determination to avenge the Arab defeat of 1948 made him the undisputed leader of the Arab world, setting Egypt and Israel on a direct collision course that would culminate in the 1956 Suez Crisis.

Q14. How did David Ben-Gurion attempt to deter Fedayeen border raids, and what was the consequence?

Q15. Explain how cross-border Fedayeen raids and Israeli reprisal strikes increased border tensions between 1950 and 1955.

Pair & Share Activity

Q16. Why do you think the well-equipped Arab armies were defeated by the newly formed Israeli Defense Forces?

Source F : Palestinian Refugees Fleeing Galilee During the 1948 Nakba



Palestinian Arabs displaced from Galilee carrying their possessions along dusty roads in late 1948.

Q17 What were the primary causes of the flight of over 700,000 Palestinian Arabs between 1947 and 1949?

Source G : David Ben-Gurion Declaring Israeli Independence (14 May 1948)



David Ben-Gurion reading the Declaration of Independence beneath the portrait of Theodor Herzl at the Tel Aviv Museum on 14 May 1948.

Q18 Why was the declaration of Israeli statehood viewed by Jewish people as historic national redemption, but by Arab states as an illegitimate catastrophe?

L4: KT 1.3: Increased Tension, Nasser, and the Suez Crisis, 1955–1963

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

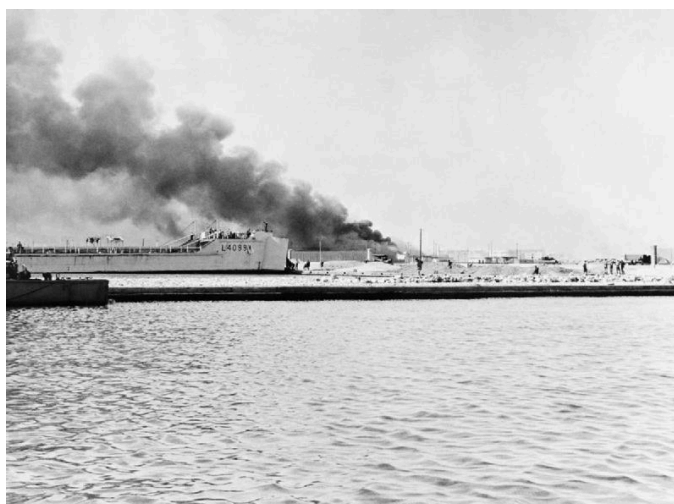
- ☐ Understand Nasser and Egypt's leadership of the Arab world.
- ☐ Analyze the events and significance of Israeli attacks on Gaza in 1955 and Sinai in 1956.
- ☐ Evaluate the events and significance of the Suez Crisis (1956), including the formation of the United Arab Republic (UAR) in 1958.

By the 1950s, the Cold War had arrived in the Middle East. Egypt's charismatic new leader, Gamal Abdel Nasser, emerged as a hero of Arab nationalism, willing to stand up to the old European empires and Israel. When he nationalised the Suez Canal, it triggered a global crisis that almost sparked World War Three.

Did you know?

- 1956: Nasser nationalised the Suez Canal, taking it back from British and French control.
- Protocol of Sèvres: A secret agreement where Israel, Britain, and France planned to invade Egypt together.
- Superpower Intervention: The US and Soviet Union forced Britain, France, and Israel to withdraw, humiliating the old empires.

Source A : British Troops Landing at Port Said During the Suez Invasion (November 1956)



British landing craft disembarking soldiers and vehicles amid burning oil storage tanks at Port Said, Egypt, during Operation Musketeer in November 1956.

Q1. Why did the Anglo-French military intervention at Suez backfire so disastrously on the international stage?

Do Now Activity

What term do Palestinians use to describe the catastrophe of their expulsion and displacement in 1948?

Approximately how many Palestinian Arabs became refugees during the 1948–49 War?

What was the name of the de facto armistice boundary line drawn on maps in 1949?

Which neighboring Arab kingdom annexed the West Bank and East Jerusalem following the 1948 War?

Which Arab nation retained administrative military control over the Gaza Strip after 1949?

What legislation passed by Israel in 1950 granted every Jewish person worldwide the legal right to immigrate to Israel?

What was the unified national army established by David Ben-Gurion in 1948?

Which global superpower provided extensive financial loans and diplomatic backing to Israel in the early 1950s?

What was the decisive 4-week turning point in June 1948 that allowed Israel to rearm with Czech weapons?

Who served as Israel's first Prime Minister from 1948 to 1953?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Pan-Arabism | Czech Arms Deal | Nationalisation | Protocol of Sèvres | UNEF

Driven by the ideology of _____, sought to modernize Egypt. Following the _____, the West refused to fund his dam project. In retaliation, Nasser announced the _____ of the Suez Canal. This led to the secret _____ where Israel, Britain, and France invaded Egypt. The conflict ended with the deployment of _____ peacekeepers in the Sinai.

Source B : President Gamal Abdel Nasser (1956)



Front page of Egyptian newspaper Al-Ahram (27 July 1956) reporting President Nasser's speech in Alexandria nationalising the Suez Canal Company.

Q2 Source Detective: Look at the celebratory front page: why was the nationalisation of the canal seen across the Arab world as a historic victory over Western imperialism?

The Rise of Gamal Abdel Nasser & Pan-Arab Nationalism: The fragile status quo established by the 1949 armistice was permanently shattered by political upheavals inside Egypt. In July 1952, a group of nationalist army officers known as the "Free Officers Movement" overthrew Egypt's corrupt, pro-Western monarch, King Farouk. By 1954, the charismatic and fiercely anti-imperialist Colonel Gamal Abdel Nasser

emerged as the undisputed President of Egypt. Nasser quickly positioned himself as the champion of Pan-Arabism—a powerful political ideology aimed at uniting Arab nations to throw off Western colonial influence, secure Arab dignity, and avenge the humiliating 1948 defeat by Israel.

Nasser's Political Vision: Non-Alignment and Arab Dignity:



The Aswan High Dam: The Linchpin of Modern Egypt: Nasser's immediate political objectives were both local and geopolitical. Although Egypt was technically independent, 80,000 British troops still occupied the strategically vital Suez Canal Zone. Nasser immediately placed heavy diplomatic pressure on Britain, successfully forcing them to sign an agreement to withdraw their forces by June 1956. Nasser initiated sweeping domestic reforms to help the poor Egyptian peasants (fellahin), including the redistribution of agricultural land and the construction of thousands of state schools and clinics.

Q3. What were Gamal Abdel Nasser's immediate political and domestic objectives after taking power in Egypt?

The Czech Arms Deal (September 1955): A Superpower Shock: The cornerstone of Nasser's developmental vision was the construction of a massive hydroelectric dam on the River Nile at Aswan. This monumental engineering project was designed to control the annual flooding of the Nile, provide clean electricity for industrialization, and irrigate millions of acres of desert land to feed Egypt's growing population. To fund this expensive project, Egypt required massive financial loans from Western powers, primarily the United States and Great Britain. Tensions between Egypt and Israel escalated dramatically on 28 February 1955 during the Gaza Raid. In retaliation for the ambush and murder of an Israeli civilian, Prime Minister David Ben-Gurion ordered the IDF to launch a massive reprisal raid against an Egyptian military headquarters in the Gaza Strip. The attack was devastating: IDF paratroopers blew up the garrison, killing 38 Egyptian soldiers and leaving Nasser's army thoroughly humiliated.

Q4. Why did Israel launch a devastating reprisal raid on the Gaza Strip on 28 February 1955, and what was the result?

The Israeli Gaza Raid (February 1955): The Fatal Turning Point:



Western Retaliation: Dulles Cancels Dam Financing (July 1956): The Gaza Raid served as a turning point for Nasser, proving that his forces were too weakly equipped to deter Israeli military power. When the United States refused to sell him weapons without political strings attached, Nasser turned to the Soviet bloc. In September 1955, Nasser stunned the West by signing the Czech Arms Deal. Under this agreement, Czechoslovakia (acting as a front for the Soviet Union) supplied Egypt with a massive arsenal of modern military hardware, including 200 advanced MiG-15 jet fighters, 300 modern tanks, and heavy artillery. This deal brought the Cold War directly into the heart of the Middle East, deeply alarming both Israel and the Western powers.

Q5. What was the significance of the 1955 Czech Arms Deal for the balance of power in the Middle East?



Al-Ahram banner headline declaring: "Nationalisation of the Suez Canal Company... our rights are restored."

Q6 Source Detective: How did Nasser use the revenue of the canal to fund the construction of the Aswan High Dam after Western loans were cancelled?

The Nationalisation of the Suez Canal (26 July 1956): In response to Nasser's Soviet alignment and his continued support for Gaza-based Fedayeen raids (which killed 58 Israeli civilians in April 1956 alone), the United States and Great Britain took retaliatory economic action. In July 1956, they abruptly withdrew their joint offer to finance the Aswan High Dam. Nasser refused to let his pride project die. On 26 July 1956, he delivered a fiery speech in Alexandria and announced the nationalisation of the Suez Canal Company. He declared that Egypt would seize the canal from its British and French shareholders and use the £35 million annual toll revenues to directly fund the construction of the Aswan High Dam.

Q7. How did President Nasser respond when the United States and Great Britain abruptly withdrew their funding for the Aswan High Dam?

Imperial Outrage: Eden and Mollet Plot Military Intervention: The nationalisation of the Suez Canal outraged Great Britain and France. British Prime Minister Anthony Eden viewed Nasser as a dangerous dictator who threatened Europe's vital oil supply line. Behind the scenes, Britain and France colluded with Israel to plan a military intervention to overthrow Nasser and retake the canal. This conspiracy was codified in the highly secret Protocol of Sèvres in October 1956.

Q8 Protocol of Sèvres Collusion Matrix: Complete the table below analyzing the secret conspiracy forged between Britain, France, and Israel in October 1956:

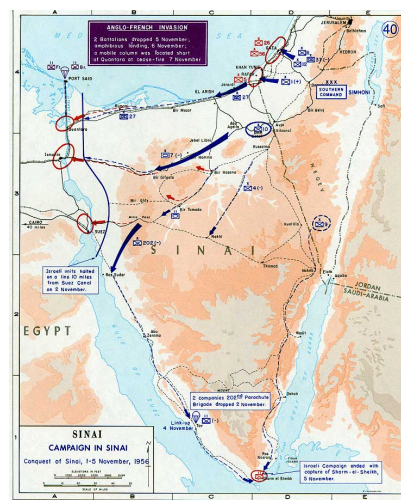
Conspiring Nation	Key National Motive / Grievance	Agreed Secret Role in Operation Kadesh

Q9. What was the secret Protocol of Sèvres in October 1956?

The Sèvres Protocol (October 1956): The Secret Tripartite Collusion:

 sevres_protocol

Source D : Military Campaign Map: The 1956 Suez Crisis & Operation Kadesh



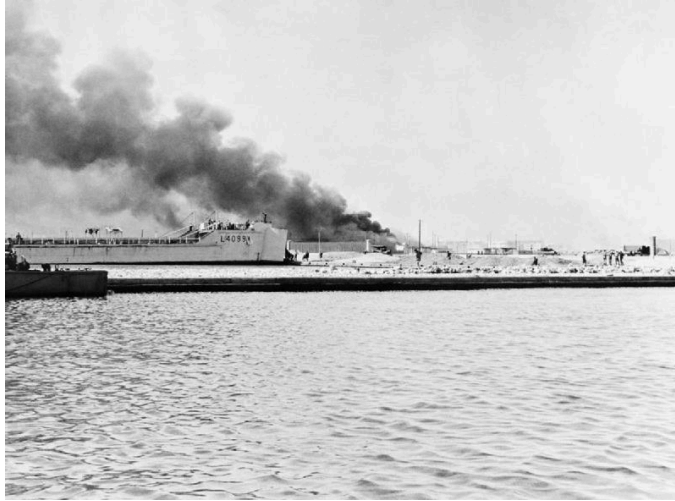
Military map illustrating the rapid Israeli armoured advance across the Sinai Peninsula, paratrooper drops at the Mitla Pass, isolation of Sharm el-Sheikh, and Anglo-French amphibious landings at Port Said.

Q10 Source Detective: Study the troop movements on the map. How did the rapid Israeli capture of the Mitla Pass and Sinai allow Britain and France to claim they were merely intervening as "peacekeepers" to protect the Suez Canal?

Operation Kadesh: The Israeli Armored Sweep Across Sinai: Under this secret tripartite plan, Israel would launch a pre-emptive strike across the Sinai Desert toward the Suez Canal. Once hostilities began, Britain and France would issue an ultimatum to both sides to stop fighting and pull back ten miles from the canal. Knowing Egypt would refuse to abandon its own territory, Britain and France would then launch an air and sea invasion to occupy the Suez Canal Zone under the guise of "protecting" international shipping.

Q11. Explain how Britain and France planned to use an Israeli invasion of the Sinai as a pretext to retake the Suez Canal.

Source E : British Forces Landing at Port Said (Operation Musketeer, Nov 1956)



Imperial War Museum Photograph MH23500: Royal Navy landing craft landing British commandos at Port Said as oil storage tanks burn.

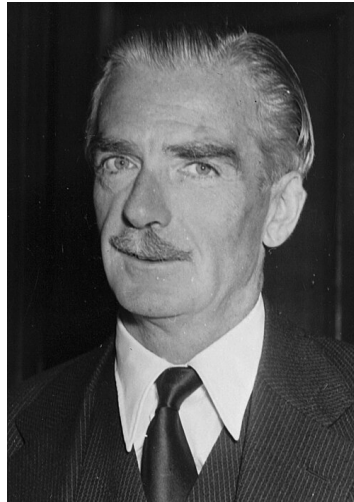
Q12 Source Detective: Why did Britain and France claim they were entering Egypt as neutral peacekeepers to separate Israeli and Egyptian armies when the Sèvres Protocol proved they had pre-planned the war together?

Operation Musketeer: Anglo-French Airborne Assault on Port Said: On 29 October 1956, the plan was put into action. The IDF launched a highly successful blitzkrieg across Sinai, routing the Egyptian army and advancing rapidly toward the canal. Britain and France immediately issued their pre-planned ultimatum and, as expected, launched heavy bombing raids and landed paratroopers at Port Said to seize control of the canal. The conspiracy backfired due to furious resistance from the global superpowers. Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev threatened to launch nuclear missile strikes against London and Paris. More decisively, US President Dwight D. Eisenhower was outraged that his allies had launched a war without consulting him, fearing it would drive the entire Arab world into the arms of the USSR. Eisenhower applied massive economic pressure on Great Britain, threatening to refuse loans and block Britain's access to oil.

Q13. Why did the Anglo-French-Israeli conspiracy backfire and end in a humiliating retreat?

The Superpower Hammer: Eisenhower's Financial Ultimatum: Buckling under American financial pressure, Britain and France were forced into a humiliating retreat, withdrawing their forces by December 1956. Israel, under intense US pressure, was forced to return the entire Sinai Peninsula to Egypt in early 1957. While the Suez Crisis was a political humiliation for Britain and France, it fundamentally transformed the security situation in the Middle East.

Source F : Prime Minister Anthony Eden Defending the Suez Operation (November 1956)



British Prime Minister Anthony Eden (center), whose career was ruined by the failure of the Suez intervention.

The Humiliation of Empires & The Resignation of Anthony Eden:

For Egypt and Nasser	For Israel's Security	For the Cold War
Nasser emerged from the crisis as an undisputed Arab folk hero . Although his army had been defeated on the battlefield, he had successfully stood up to British, French, and Israeli "imperialism" and kept control of the Suez Canal, cementing Egypt's leadership of the Arab world.	Israel scored massive military and strategic benefits. The IDF had proven its unquestioned military superiority , routing the Egyptian army in just a few days, which acted as a powerful deterrent against future Arab invasions.	The Middle East became a central theater of the Cold War. British and French colonial influence in the region was permanently broken, replaced by direct US support for Israel and Soviet backing for Egypt and Syria .

Geopolitical Consequences: Superpowers Replace Colonial Powers:



UN Peacekeepers (UNEF) in Sinai & Freedom of Navigation: Crucially, Israel's forced withdrawal from the Sinai Peninsula was conditioned on three vital security guarantees. First, the United Nations deployed its first-ever peacekeeping force, the United Nations Emergency Force (UNEF), along the Gaza border and the Sinai Desert. This UNEF buffer successfully halted the Gaza Fedayeen raids, guaranteeing Israel ten years of relative border security. Second, the UNEF took control of Sharm el-Sheikh, forcing Egypt to lift its naval blockade. The Straits of Tiran were reopened to Israeli vessels, allowing Eilat to flourish as a vital trade port for oil, materials, and commerce with Asia and East Africa.

Q14. Identify two vital security guarantees Israel received in exchange for withdrawing its forces from the Sinai Peninsula.

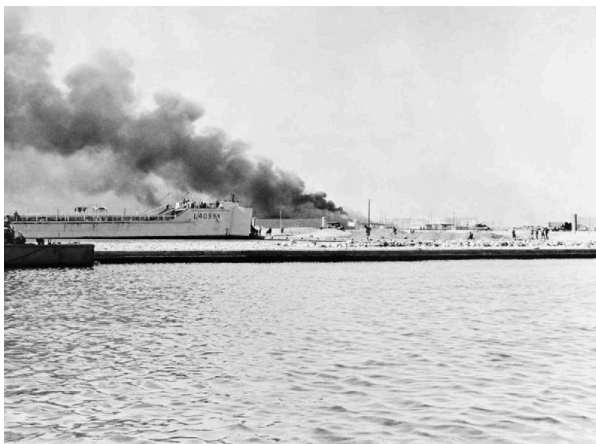
Nasser's Apotheosis: The Peak of Pan-Arab Heroism: Finally, the political momentum of Nasser's victory led directly to the formation of the United Arab Republic (UAR) in February 1958—a total political and military union between Egypt and Syria. While this union increased Israeli fears of encirclement, it also locked the region into an uneasy, highly armed decade-long stalemate that lasted until 1967.

Q15. Explain why Nasser's nationalisation of the Suez Canal led Britain, France, and Israel to collude against Egypt.

Pair & Share Activity

Q16. Why was the Suez Canal so important to Britain and France that they were willing to go to war over it?

Source G : British Troops Landing at Port Said (November 1956)



British amphibious assault troops entering Port Said against Egyptian resistance.

Q17 How did British Prime Minister Anthony Eden justify the military intervention, and why did US President Eisenhower oppose it?

Source H : Cairo Newspaper Al-Ahram Announcing the Suez Nationalisation (July 1956)



The front page of Cairo's leading daily Al-Ahram featuring Gamal Abdel Nasser's announcement nationalising the Suez Canal Company.

Q18 Why did Nasser's nationalisation of the Suez Canal make him an instant hero of Pan-Arab nationalism across the Middle East?